

AFTERLIVES
by Abdulrazak Gurnah
BLOOMSBURY
₹499; 288 pages

AFTERLIVES IS SET AGAINST THE BACKDROP OF COLONIAL BRUTALITY AND REPRESSION IN EASTERN AFRICA

will turn dark with African blood shed in a struggle between Europeans. We encounter Khalifa, son of an African mother and an immigrant Gujarati Muslim father, whose decency and kindness radiate through the novel. Two other characters, Ilyas and Hamza, are part of the Schutztruppen—the first stolen by it, including in spirit; the other sold to it. Hamza's experience of colonial sadism leaves him literally and figuratively broken, though he learns German and can read Schiller. He meets Ilyas's sister, Afiya, herself a survivor of abuse, and their tender love story becomes the pathway from trauma to recovery. The novel ends in the 1950s, when their son, also Ilyas, pieces together the lost, grim history of his namesake uncle.

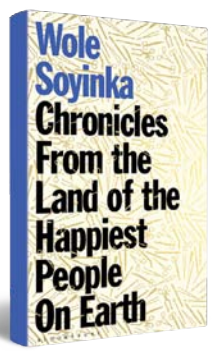
That act of recuperation stands for Gurnah's own attempt to make and remake past worlds. His gaze can be panoramic and vast, taking in the historical movements that shape individual lives. But it is always attuned to the inner experience of those lives, conveying them organically, believably, vividly—in language that is spare and free of pyrotechnics, but ambitious in its inclusion of Kiswahili, Arabic and German words. He similarly expands the category of 'historical fiction' to make room for the affective and the magical. What we know in the present is always shot through by a past that haunts and eludes us; this is truth as afterlife, a truth that 'cannot achieve completion'. ■

—Mandakini Dubey

readers will note that the priest was first inspired by the vast domain of Guru Mahara Ji along the expressway leading from Lagos. In fact, many details strike close to home—the faith of the poor in injections over pills, the economic uses of year-round festivals and the declaration of Prime Minister Sir Godfrey Danfere that nowhere does he hear one dissenting voice among the Happiest People on Earth.

Sir Goddie has just concluded a huge debate, with input from his supporters, on whether he should be addressed as the National Servant, the Nation's Serf, the People's Valet, General Factotum or the People's Steward. Once they settle on the most "grassy-rootsy" of these, he is ready to deal with the larger problem of eliminating the renowned engineer Duyole Pitan-Payne, who has inconveniently demonstrated that Nigeria's power shortages can be resolved without help from the World Bank or the IMF. Pitan-Payne is about to leave Nigeria to work for the UN, and Sir Goddie is glad to see him go.

Pitan-Payne's boyhood friend Kighare Menka, now a surgeon being feted by the elite of Lagos at a colonially



CHRONICLES FROM THE LAND OF THE HAPPIEST PEOPLE ON EARTH
by Wole Soyinka
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hung-over club, blurts out to his audience his discovery of an appalling trade in "human resources" that has been sloshing under his nose for some time. It is supplied by bomb blasts, road accidents and everyday killings, and it feeds something far more barbaric than the transplant industry.

Soyinka's prose is dense, broken up by an occasional set piece and intriguing side tracks, the narrative often a bewildering tangle of pathways, like the history of any troubled society. Still, it shows us fleeting but persistent glimpses of the ideals of young men who once thought to fashion a different nation. ■

—Latha Anantharaman